

THE CARTOGRAPHER

of Small Islands



A SHORT STORY

CHAPTER 1

The Drawer

The harbour master kept a drawer of maps that nobody had asked for. Each one showed an island no larger than a kitchen table, drawn with the same care as a continent.

He had started the habit as a boy, when his father let him hold the end of the measuring chain. Now the drawer would barely close, and he had begun a second one.

There were islands shaped like spoons and islands shaped like sleeping dogs. One, which he loved most, was the exact outline of his late wife's left hand.

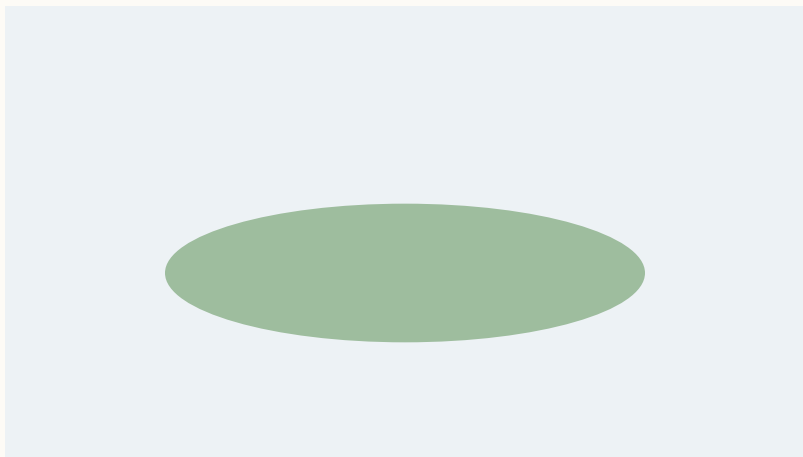


Plate 1. An island, surveyed at low tide.

The sea did not care for his maps, and he did not ask it to. A map, he believed, was a way of paying attention, and attention was the only rent he could afford.

By the time the tide turned, he would be back on the quay with wet ankles and a page full of numbers, already arguing with himself about the shape of a single stone.

Some days he drew nothing at all. He only watched, which he said was also a kind of drawing, only slower.

CHAPTER 2

Low Tide

He measured them at low tide with a knotted rope and a borrowed compass, wading out with his trousers rolled and his notebook tucked inside his hat.

Low tide was honest. It showed the rocks the sea preferred to hide, and the long ribs of sand that joined one small island to the next for an hour or two each day.

On those mornings the harbour looked less like water and more like a sentence that had not been finished.

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CHAPTER 3

Ink and Lamp

In the evenings he sat by the lamp and inked every rock, every tuft of grass, every place where a gull had decided to nest.

He used three nibs and one bottle of ink a year. The fine nib was for coastlines, the broad one for names, and the middle one for everything he was not yet sure about.

He never used colour. Colour, he said, was a promise the weather would break.

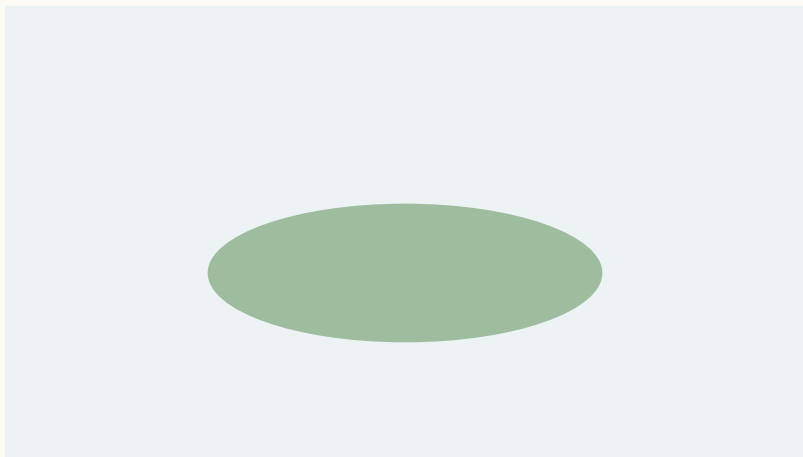


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CHAPTER 4

Visitors

Visitors laughed at first. A map of a rock, they said, was just a rock with extra steps.

Then they began to notice how the small maps made the sea feel smaller too, as if the whole horizon could be folded and carried home in a coat pocket.

A schoolteacher asked for a copy for her classroom. A fisherman asked for the one with the sunken wall, because his nets kept tearing there and now he knew why.

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CHAPTER 5

Winter Maps

In winter the islands vanished under grey water and he redrew them from memory, which was not the same as drawing them wrong.

Memory added a tree where there had only been a hope of one. It moved a rock a little closer to its neighbour, as if the two had grown fond of each other over the summer.

He kept these winter maps in a separate folder, labelled in small letters: Possible.

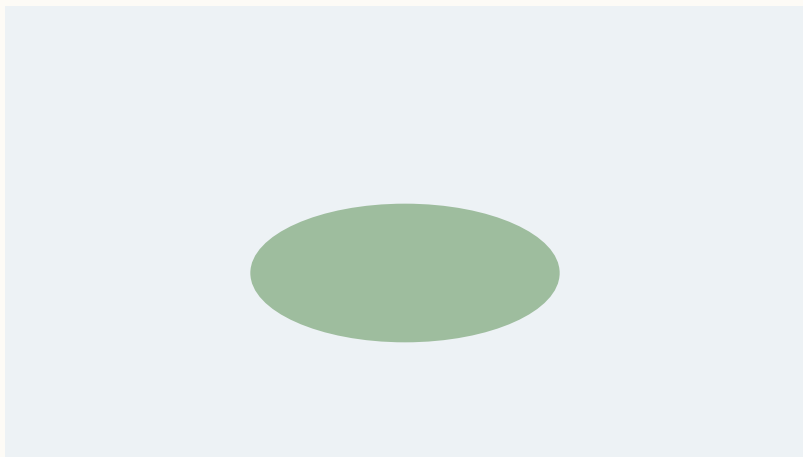


Plate 3. An island, surveyed at low tide.

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CHAPTER 6

The Last Island

The spring he turned eighty, a new island rose a little north of the breakwater: a hump of shingle the storms had built and forgotten.

He measured it slowly, resting between knots. He named it after nobody, which was the kindest name he knew, and he left a corner of the map blank on purpose.

Somewhere, he wrote beneath it, there should always be a little room for the sea to change its mind.

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*“A map is a promise that
somewhere is worth returning to.”*

